3

RAILWAYS BEGIN THEIR OPERATIONS

A Race to the Finish

LAYING THE FOUNDATION

What we read in the earlier chapters were details of early experiments, which, when documented, help stitch together India's railway history.

Since the 1830s, there were experiments at various levels with rail tracks and steam power. In the 1840s, in line with the developments in England and many other countries, railway lines were proposed to be laid in India, with parliamentarians and business tycoons lobbying for or against it. The challenge was to make them financially viable and sustainable—with most businessmen wanting guaranteed returns on investment, and the planners and strategists wanting the railways to be a vital means of imports and of military importance. Long-drawn debates and documentation took place. The key subject of dispute on the table was that after the huge investments of construction and operation, would the 'natives' accept this new development at all? Would there be substantial returns? The construction of railway lines across an unfamiliar terrain came with an element of risk. The promoters were confident, but there were wary officials and a few parliamentarians who remained divided in their opinion. There were, of course, profits to be made.

A paper presented in October 1847 before the House of Commons discussed trade relations between India and England, focussing specifically on cotton. Cotton, it said, grew in the interiors of India, in places without transport and communication facilities. Therefore, by the time it reached the